

Soul Tribe

A friendship-first platform that turns precise compatibility into real-life outings people actually attend — and want to repeat.



PRODUCT THESIS

**Meaningful
friendships created**

HERO MECHANIC

**Host-curated Pitch
Outings**

MATCHING LAYER

Friendship DNA

00 What changed in v2.0

READ FIRST

Version 1.0 defined the product. Version 2.0 makes it buildable: the matching model is now specified as math rather than an illustrative weighting, the hero mechanic has hard constraints, and the technical direction has changed. Everything below is a deliberate supersession of v1.0 — nothing here is a drafting difference.

AREA	V1.0 SAID	V2.0 SAYS, AND WHY
Matching model	Eight weighted components, including a 5% "complementarity bonus" and 3% behavioural learning.	Ten dimensions summing to 100 , split into <i>Resonance</i> (73, psychological) and <i>Logistics</i> (27, practical), combined geometrically. Complementarity is no longer a bonus — it is a per-trait property, because some traits genuinely work through difference. Behavioural learning becomes a recalibration loop, not a weight.
Single score	One illustrative compatibility score.	Two scores that never average. High Resonance with low Logistics is a bad recommendation, not a near-miss. Two people who would love each other but can never meet should not be surfaced.
Expectation matching	Not addressed.	New scoring mode. Communication and contact cadence score behaviour against the other person's <i>expectation</i> , both directions. Two people who each reply in two days and each expect that are highly compatible — v1.0 had no way to express this.
Emotional style	An optional consent-based layer.	Emotional Rhythm — a named five-part sub-model (opening pace, contact cadence, reassurance need ↔ offering, recovery time, conflict approach) carrying 70% of the dimension. Still consent-based and skippable.
Group size	"Capacity" configurable by host.	Hard cap of six participants including the host on the standard tier, enforced in Postgres — not only in the UI. Six is where conversation splits.
Interests	Tags plus free text.	An interest graph with affinity levels, and a deliberate bonus for pairing "always wanted to try" with "already does this".
Client platform	React Native with Expo.	Next.js installable PWA first, native later , with all business logic in a framework-free shared core package. Faster to the 30-person test; native stays cheap.
Scope	Broad P0 including full messaging.	Narrowed to four things: onboarding, matching, host-controlled pitching, outing artifacts. Chat is a thin coordination thread, not a chat product. Flash Pods, Echo Room and the interactive Tribe Map are explicitly deferred.
Design law	Implicit.	Explicit and enforced: every feature must produce a persistent artifact that chat cannot replicate. If you cannot name the artifact, do not build the feature.

AREA	V1.0 SAID	V2.0 SAYS, AND WHY
Visual direction	Warm palette, editorial type, moodboard reference.	A specified system with tokens, the Friendship DNA Bloom, the Rhythm Strip, and a list of banned patterns. The v1.0 moodboard is retired — its imagery contained generated placeholder text and is not a usable reference.

CARRIED FORWARD UNCHANGED

The product thesis, positioning, primary users, safety model, reporting taxonomy, edge-case rules, launch sequencing and the Meaningful Friendship Starts north star all survive v1.0 intact. They were right.

01 Product definition

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

ONE-LINE PRODUCT

Soul Tribe helps people understand their friendship needs, discover genuinely compatible people, and turn that compatibility into curated real-life outings.

Soul Tribe is deliberately not a dating app, not a swipe-based friend marketplace, not an events directory, and not another feed optimised for attention. It is a **coordination layer above chat**, designed around one measurable outcome: meaningful friendships created.

The product thesis

Adult friendship fails less from a lack of people than from weak discovery, shallow compatibility signals, social uncertainty, and the friction of turning "we should hang out" into an actual plan. Soul Tribe solves these as one connected system:

1. Help users articulate who they are and what kind of friendship fits their current life season.
2. Match people on multidimensional Friendship DNA rather than interests alone.
3. Give users agency through Pitch Outings: specific real-life plans others request to join.
4. Let hosts curate attendance using compatibility, context and safety signals.
5. Learn from real-world outcomes so future matches and outings improve.

The design law V2.0

Every feature must produce a persistent artifact that chat cannot replicate. This is the test a feature has to pass before it enters the backlog.

FEATURE	ARTIFACT IT PRODUCES
Onboarding	Friendship DNA — a living portrait that sharpens over time
Matching	Resonance Read — why you would click, and where you would rub
Pitch Outing	Outing Record — who came, what happened, one line worth keeping
Post-outing	Rhythm Check — private feedback that visibly recalibrates future matches

MVP promise

Within the first session, a user should feel seen. Within the first week, they should find at least one person or outing that feels unusually relevant. Within the first month, the product should help them attend or host a real-world interaction worth repeating.

MVP OBJECTIVE	USER EVIDENCE	BUSINESS EVIDENCE
Prove precise matching	Users say "this feels like me" and open match explanations	High profile completion and match-detail views
Prove outing conversion	Users request, are approved, and attend	Request-to-accept and accept-to-attend conversion
Prove the learning loop	Feedback visibly improves later recommendations	Repeat outing and second-session retention
Prove emotional safety	Users feel in control and respected	Low report rate, strong safety sentiment
Prove honest explanation V2.0	Users describe the friction section as accurate, not just the positive one	Explanation expansion rate; qualitative review pass

02 Strategic foundation

VISION, POSITIONING, PRINCIPLES

Vision

Make adult friendship as intentional, intelligible and actionable as finding a dream job — without turning human connection into a transaction.

Positioning

SOUL TRIBE IS	SOUL TRIBE IS NOT
A friendship-first social platform	A dating product with a friendship mode
A coordination layer above chat	An endless content feed
Host-curated and autonomy-led	A random group matching system
Emotionally precise and explainable	A black-box compatibility score
Dense, local and quality-first	A scale-at-all-costs global directory

Product principles

PRINCIPLE	DESIGN IMPLICATION
Agency before abundance	Users choose what to do, who may join, and how visible they are.
Depth without oversharing	Reveal useful compatibility progressively; never force intimate disclosure.
Explain the match	Every recommendation states why it may work <i>and</i> where friction may arise. The friction section is mandatory and never collapsed.

PRINCIPLE	DESIGN IMPLICATION
Offline is the outcome	Optimise for attended interactions and repeat connection, not screen time.
Warm, not childish	Gentle ritual and light delight; no cheap points, streak anxiety or casino mechanics.
Safety is product design	Verification, boundaries, location privacy, host controls and reporting are core flows.
Every feature leaves something behind V2.0	If a feature produces nothing a group chat could not, it does not ship.

Primary users

SEGMENT	NEED STATE	MVP JOB TO BE DONE
The intentional seeker	Wants deeper friendships but dislikes shallow social apps	Find people who match emotional and conversational depth
The life-transition user	New city, new job, breakup, graduation or identity shift	Build a local social life without starting from zero
The selective introvert / ambivert	Open to connection but drained by large, random groups	Join low-pressure, clearly framed outings
The community catalyst	Enjoys convening people and shaping a vibe	Host curated outings with control over attendance
The overlooked multidimensional person	Feels reduced to hobbies or demographics	Be understood through personality, rhythm and values

Test cohort for v0.1: Singapore-based adults, roughly 26–40, whose social circle quietly thinned after a move, a life-stage change, or an all-consuming work period. They are not socially anxious — they are time-poor and initiative-fatigued.

03 How Soul Tribe works

THE CORE LOOP

NORTH-STAR LOOP

Discover yourself → build Friendship DNA → discover compatible people and outings → pitch or request → host curates → meet offline → reflect → the model learns → a better next connection.

How a user "wins"

Winning is not collecting followers or maximising matches. A user wins when Soul Tribe helps them create one or more reciprocal relationships that continue beyond the app. The product should progressively become less necessary for any individual friendship while remaining useful as a trusted source of new connection.

Primary loops

LOOP	TRIGGER	ACTION	REWARD	LEARNING SIGNAL
Self-discovery	Onboarding or profile prompt	Complete a Friendship DNA layer	A useful personal insight	Profile depth and confidence
Discovery	Soul Drop, search or open app	Review people and outings	A recommendation that feels unusually relevant	View, save, dismiss, explanation opened
Outing conversion	Compelling outing or idea	Request to join, or pitch one	A concrete plan with social clarity	Accept/decline, fit and availability
Real-world outcome	Upcoming outing	Attend and interact	Belonging, enjoyment or useful connection	Attendance and private Rhythm Check
Continuation	Positive outing	Reconnect, invite or repeat	A friendship starts to compound	Repeat interaction and mutual intent

Gameplay patterns without gamifying friendship

- **Progressive revelation** — deeper profile layers unlock more precise explanations. Progress is shown as the Bloom thickening, never as a percentage or a bar.
- **Curated scarcity** — a small weekly Soul Drop, capped at five people, feels considered rather than infinite.
- **Reciprocity** — "You First" prompts ask the user to contribute before selected peer responses unlock.
- **Agency and consequence** — host choices shape the room; reliability and feedback improve future access.
- **Memory and meaning** — Outing Records turn real interactions into an evolving personal social history.

04 What to build now

SCOPE AND RELEASE BOUNDARY

The MVP exists to answer one question: does dimensional matching plus host-controlled pitching produce meetups that people attend and want to repeat?

PO — REQUIRED FOR MVP

CAPABILITY	INCLUDED IN MVP	ACCEPTANCE SUMMARY
Account and identity	Magic-link and Apple sign-in, age gate, display name, photo, home area	User can create, edit and deactivate an account
Friendship DNA	Progressive onboarding: 12-question core pass, then optional deepening layers	User receives a readable, editable profile summary; matching unlocks at confidence ≥ 0.55
Discovery	People cards, outing cards, filters, weekly Soul Drop capped at five	Every recommendation carries specific fit reasons and a friction note

CAPABILITY	INCLUDED IN MVP	ACCEPTANCE SUMMARY
Pitch Outings	Create, publish, edit, cancel, manage capacity to a maximum of six	Host controls context, audience and approval; cap enforced at the database
Join requests	Request note, status, withdraw	Host sees a fit summary and can accept or decline
Host curation	Applicant list, compatibility context, live group-cohesion advisories	Capacity and approval rules remain consistent; advisories never block the host
Coordination thread	Thin outing thread after acceptance, with hand-off to the group's own chat	No unsolicited contact before mutual context exists
Attendance	RSVP status, reminders, check-in confirmation	App records attended, cancelled and no-show states
Outing Record	Headline, photo, attendees	A durable artifact exists for every completed outing
Rhythm Check	Private post-outing reflection at +24h	Signals update recommendations; never visible to the person they concern
Trust and safety	Block, report, privacy settings, moderation queue	User can exit and report any unsafe interaction within two taps

P1 — NEXT AFTER PROOF

- Identity verification and reliability badges.
- Flash Pods — spontaneous same-day micro-meetups.
- Echo Room — asynchronous reflection space.
- Interactive Tribe Map.
- Recurring circles and repeat-outing templates.
- Venue partnerships and paid micro-events.

EXPLICITLY OUT OF MVP

- AR Freeze Frames, spatial photos, splat memory worlds.
- Public follower counts, creator feeds, repost mechanics.
- Open direct messaging between strangers.
- Subscriptions before offline conversion is proven.
- Native apps — web PWA only for the closed test.
- Global launch; dense Singapore clusters first.

NOTE ON THE DEFERRALS

Flash Pods, Echo Room and the Tribe Map are strong ideas and remain in the product vision. They are deferred because none of them tests the MVP question, and each adds a state machine. The data model accommodates all three; a simplified static Tribe Map ships as the profile backdrop in v0.1 so the metaphor exists from day one.

05 Friendship DNA

THE MATCHING FOUNDATION

Friendship DNA is both a self-understanding experience and the structured data layer behind recommendations. It should feel like a thoughtful conversation, not a clinical test or a hundred-question form.

Dimension model and weights REVISED

Ten dimensions, summing to 100, split into two groups that are scored and displayed separately. Weights are fixed for v0.1 and tuned only against real outcome data.

DIMENSION	WEIGHT	GROUP	WHAT IT CAPTURES
Personality compatibility	15	Resonance	Big Five plus friendship-relevant poles: serious ↔ playful, intensity ↔ easygoing, assertive ↔ accommodating, novelty seeking
Communication compatibility	15	Resonance	Medium, frequency, conversation style, response speed, directness, initiation — scored against expectation
Social rhythm	15	Logistics	Availability, planning horizon, frequency, preferred duration, energy window
Friendship needs and intentions	15	Resonance	What kind of friendship, and at what depth, right now
Emotional / relational style	10	Resonance	Emotional Rhythm (70%) plus static style: expressiveness, vulnerability, affection, boundaries
Interests and curiosity graph	10	Resonance	A tree with affinity levels, including "always wanted to try"
Values and worldview	8	Resonance	Stance <i>and</i> how much it matters that a friend shares it
Lifestyle compatibility	7	Logistics	Budget band, alcohol, activity level, food, life stage, travel frequency, accessibility
Experience / outing compatibility	3	Logistics	Setting, group size, conversation-first vs activity-first, novelty appetite
Geography	2 + gate	Logistics	Mobility radius that varies by activity, not a single kilometre figure

Resonance = 73 points. Logistics = 27 points. Each is normalised within its group to a 0–1 value. Neither is ever shown to a user as a number.

Collection method

LAYER	QUESTIONS	TIME	UNLOCKS
Core pass	12	~4 min	Matching turns on (confidence ≈ 0.60)
Deepening A — rhythm	8	~3 min	Sharper availability and communication fit
Deepening B — Emotional Rhythm	9	~4 min	The layer that makes the reads feel accurate
Deepening C — interests and values	Open	Ongoing	Better outing suggestions and value alignment

Every question is either a choice between written human statements, a slider between two named poles, or a chip multi-select. **No question is ever presented as a 1–5 Likert scale.** People answer honestly when the options sound like things a person would say.

NEVER ASKED

Income, race, religion, nationality, health conditions or relationship status. None are inputs to the model, and asking makes the product feel invasive. Budget is asked as an outing band, never as income.

CRITICAL RULE — UNCHANGED FROM V1.0

The AI summary must never present personality inference as objective truth. Use language such as "You seem to prefer..." and let the user correct every interpretation. Every generated sentence can be edited, hidden or regenerated.

06

Explainable compatibility

MATCHING LOGIC

Deterministic scoring for eligibility and ranking; a language model only to translate structured compatibility into warm, concise explanations. This keeps matching inspectable, cheap and tunable.

Two scores that never average V2.0

Two people can be psychologically well suited and still fail as friends because their lives never touch. So **Resonance** (would you enjoy each other?) and **Logistics** (can this friendship physically happen?) are computed independently and combined geometrically, so a near-zero on either side collapses the result rather than being averaged away.

$$\text{rank} = \text{Resonance}^{0.6} \times \text{Logistics}^{0.4} \times \Pi(\text{gates})$$

rank is used only to order the list. It is never displayed, never exposed through the API, and never stored anywhere the client can read.

Scoring modes V2.0

Soul Tribe does not assume similar equals compatible. Every trait declares how it is scored.

MODE	HOW IT WORKS AND WHERE IT APPLIES
Similarity	A Gaussian peaking when two people are identical. Used for intellectual curiosity, openness, agreeableness, conflict approach, recovery time.
Complementarity	The same Gaussian, offset so it peaks at a deliberate gap. A moderate planner and a moderate improviser score <i>higher</i> than two planners. Used for conscientiousness, extraversion, intensity, assertiveness, opening pace.
Expectation fit	Scores each person's behaviour against the other's expectation, in both directions, combined as a geometric mean so a one-sided mismatch is not rescued. Used for contact cadence, response speed, initiation, social frequency, support style.
Set overlap	Shared items over the smaller set, so a busy person is not penalised for having few free slots. Used for availability, mediums, conversation styles, intents, settings.

MODE	HOW IT WORKS AND WHERE IT APPLIES
Graph affinity	Interest-tree proximity multiplied by affinity, with a bonus when one side is curious and the other already does it.

Emotional Rhythm V2.0

The tempo of someone's emotional life in friendship: how fast they open, how much contact they need, how they recover, how they handle tension. Five components, 70% of the emotional dimension.

COMPONENT	MODE	PRODUCT REASONING
Opening pace	Mild complementarity	A slightly faster opener draws a guarded person out; two very guarded people often stall at acquaintance.
Contact cadence need	Expectation fit, tightest tolerance in the model	Mismatched need for contact is the leading cause of quiet friendship death.
Reassurance need ↔ offering	Cross-scored between people	A high-need person paired with a naturally reassuring person scores well <i>because</i> they differ.
Recovery / solo time	Similarity, loose	How much alone time is needed after socialising.
Conflict approach	Similarity, tight	Two conflict-avoiders are genuinely fine together. Avoider plus direct-addresser is the classic rupture — always surfaced as friction, with direction.

Presentation rule: never show clinical language. Internally a low opening pace becomes, in the interface, *"I tend to open up gradually, but I'm very loyal once I'm comfortable."* Banned words in all generated copy: avoidant, anxious, needy, clingy, cold, difficult, incompatible, red flag.

Eligibility gates

Gates are the only binary rejections in the system. Everything else reduces rank; nothing else eliminates.

- No shared availability slot at all.
- Travel time exceeds twice the smaller mobility radius for every activity category.
- A block or report exists in either direction.
- A declared dealbreaker is violated — smoking, alcohol present, unmet accessibility need.
- An explicitly set age preference band is not met.
- Profile confidence below 0.55 on either side — thin data produces bad matches, so we show none.
- Either account is under trust-and-safety review.

Explanation framework

The engine decides *what* is discussed deterministically; the model decides only *how it is said*. Selection takes the three strongest aligned dimensions and the one or two largest divergences, renders each as a pre-written human phrase, and sends only those phrases — never raw vectors, never scores — to the model.

WHY YOU MIGHT CLICK

You both want a small circle of close friendships rather than a big social network, and neither of you expects constant texting — but you both want conversations that go somewhere when you do meet. You're also usually free on Sunday afternoons and both like plans made a few days ahead.

WHERE YOU MIGHT RUB

Maya is considerably more spontaneous than you and enjoys larger groups. You tend to prefer plans in advance and groups of three or four.

FRICTION IS MANDATORY

A match explanation without a friction section is a defect, not a pleasant surprise. It is enforced by a database constraint and by a property test over every generated read. Where there is genuinely nothing to flag, the copy says so plainly rather than inventing a concern. Explaining friction is what makes the product feel trustworthy rather than like software trying to sell every match.

07 Pitch Outings

HERO FEATURE

Pitch Outings converts vague social intent into a clear, bounded invitation. The host has autonomy; joiners get enough context to decide whether it suits them.

THE RULE THAT SHAPES THE FEATURE

Soul Tribe suggests. The host decides. Nothing is ever auto-added to a guest list. Every advisory the system shows a host is an observation, never an approval or a veto.

Group size **V2.0**

Six participants, including the host, on the standard tier. The composer's slider stops hard at six with the copy: *"Six is where conversation splits. Soul Tribe stops here on purpose."* Enforcement lives in three places — a Postgres trigger, an API guard and the UI — and the trigger is the authority. Pending invitations hold a seat, so a host who has invited six cannot invite a seventh while those are outstanding.

Create-outing fields

FIELD GROUP	REQUIRED	OPTIONAL CONTROLS
Concept	Title, short pitch, activity category	Prompt-assisted wording, tagged interest node, reference image
Logistics	Date, start time, duration, neighbourhood	Exact venue hidden until accepted
Social format	Capacity (2–6), energy level	Structured vs free-flowing, conversation depth
Practical fit	Budget band, accessibility, language	Alcohol-free, indoor/outdoor, dress context
Who may request	Invite-only or matched-people-may-request	Minimum fit band, life season, shared interests

FIELD GROUP	REQUIRED	OPTIONAL CONTROLS
Host preferences	Approval required, request deadline	First-timer friendly, plus-one policy
Safety	Public venue by default, contact boundaries	Check-in reminder, trusted-contact option

Group cohesion advisories V2.0

An outing is not a set of independent pairs. As the guest list changes, the composer shows a live cohesion read — the weakest pair matters as much as the average, because in a group of four one uncomfortable pairing is the whole evening.

CONDITION	WHAT THE HOST SEES
Weakest pair scores poorly	"Priya and Marcus are quite different — that can work, but this group may need you to bridge them."
Wide energy spread	"This group's energy range is wide. Two people prefer quiet settings and one thrives in high-energy ones."
Budget bands two or more apart	"Budget expectations vary here. Naming the likely spend in your pitch will help."
Group-size preference conflict	"Two guests prefer one-to-one or small groups — six may feel like a lot for them."
No slot works for everyone	"There's no time slot that works for everyone yet." Blocks confirmation, not invitation.

Join-request flow

1. User opens an outing card and sees the idea, vibe, practical requirements, host profile and why it fits them.
2. User taps **Request to join** and answers one light host prompt — e.g. "What makes this outing appealing today?"
3. User submits; the exact location stays private until acceptance.
4. Host receives the request with a concise fit summary, the request note and reliability context.
5. Host accepts, declines or leaves pending until the deadline.
6. Accepted user enters the coordination thread and receives logistics, boundaries and reminders.
7. After the event, attendance and a private Rhythm Check close the loop.

Host control without social cruelty

- Declines use neutral system language and never expose host-selected reasons.
- Hosts set criteria before publishing rather than judging applicants against hidden standards.
- Applicants never see a ranked list of other applicants, and never see their own score.
- Capacity and deadlines prevent indefinite pending states.
- Host removal of a guest notifies neutrally, logs a reason category internally, and preserves the report path.
- Repeated discriminatory use of preferences is reviewable through policy and moderation.

SCREEN	PRIMARY PURPOSE	KEY ELEMENTS	PRIMARY ACTION
Welcome	Set expectation and safety tone	Value proposition, a specimen Resonance Read including its friction, sign in	Create account
DNA onboarding	Collect structured compatibility signals	One idea per screen, skip controls, privacy labels, Bloom thickening live	Continue
DNA reveal	Reflect the user back to themselves	Bloom completes its first draw; editable summary; matching switches on	See my matches
Home / Soul Drop	The week, not a feed	Rhythm Strip with confirmed plans, one dominant pitch or invitation, up to five people, a recent Outing Record	Open recommendation
Discover people	Browse explainable matches	Overlapping cards, paired Blooms, fit reason	Save / view profile
Person profile	Assess multidimensional fit	Resonance Read, Rhythm overlay, interest branch with curiosity items marked	Pitch something to them
Discover outings	Find concrete social plans	Pitch Cards with illustrated vignette, seats as filled and empty chairs	Request to join
Outing detail	Evaluate fit and logistics	Host's pitch in their own words, attendees, why the host chose them, boundaries	Request to join
Create outing	Turn intent into a publishable plan	Five-step composer, your own Rhythm Strip, live cohesion advisories, preview	Publish pitch
Host dashboard	Curate requests and manage the plan	Applicants with fit context and request notes, capacity, status	Accept / decline
Coordination thread	Coordinate only after context exists	Pinned details, thin thread, safety tools, hand-off to the group's own chat	Send message
Rhythm Check	Capture outcome privately	Three taps: would meet again, energy read, pace read	Submit reflection
Outing Record	Make the evening durable	Headline, photo, who was there	Save memory
Profile	Control identity and settings	Bloom, Outing Records on a Tribe Map backdrop, what changed, privacy	Edit profile
Safety centre	Immediate user control	Block, report, guidelines, support	Take action

DELIBERATE ABSENCES

No infinite scroll. No numeric notification badges. No "someone viewed your profile". No match celebration animation. No visible count of how many other people matched with someone.

09 Functional requirements

STORIES AND ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

FRIENDSHIP DNA

USER STORY	ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA
As a new user, I want onboarding to feel manageable so I do not abandon it.	The core pass is 12 questions and completes in under five minutes, shows progress as the Bloom, allows skips, autosaves and clearly labels private answers.
As a user, I want to correct the AI summary so I am not misrepresented.	Every generated sentence or dimension can be edited, hidden or regenerated.
As a user, I want to understand why data is requested.	Each sensitive layer has a "How this helps matching" explanation and an explicit consent state.
As a user with a thin profile, I do not want poor matches.	Below 0.55 confidence the user is not surfaced to anyone and sees a warm prompt naming which questions would sharpen their matches most.

DISCOVERY AND MATCHING

USER STORY	ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA
As a user, I want fewer but better recommendations.	The Soul Drop contains at most five people per week; each carries at least two specific fit reasons.
As a user, I want to avoid unsuitable contexts.	Filters and hidden constraints remove incompatible budgets, distances, accessibility needs and formats before ranking.
As a user, I want honest expectations.	Every profile shows a friction note where the data supports one, at the same visual weight as the positive section, never collapsed.
As a user, I want to know why I was shown someone.	Every surfaced match is logged with its full dimension breakdown, so the question is always answerable.

PITCH OUTINGS

USER STORY	ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA
As a host, I want control over who attends.	Approval mode, capacity, deadline and visibility are configurable and enforced server-side.
As a host, I do not want the system deciding for me.	No guest is ever auto-added. Cohesion advisories are observations and never block an invitation.
As a joiner, I want enough detail before requesting.	Outing detail shows date, broad location, cost band, duration, vibe, host and selection context.

USER STORY	ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA
As a host, I want an easy way to compare requests.	Applicant cards show the request note, relevant fit reasons and reliability — never a reductive single score.
As an attendee, I want clear logistics after acceptance.	Exact location, coordination thread, cancellation policy and reminders become available on acceptance.
As a host, I cannot exceed the group cap by accident.	A seventh accepted or pending member is rejected by the database, not only by the interface.

SAFETY AND FEEDBACK

USER STORY	ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA
As a user, I want to block or report from any relevant screen.	The action is reachable within two taps and removes contact immediately, in both directions.
As a user, I want feedback to remain private.	Hosts and attendees never see individual ratings or written reflections. The copy says so at the point of asking.
As a user, I want the app to learn without punishing normal mismatch.	One poor-fit outing changes recommendations modestly; observed signals never move a self-reported trait by more than a fifth of its scale.
As a user, I want to know when the model changed its mind about me.	Recalibration is surfaced in plain language on the profile. Nothing changes silently.

10 Reasons to return

RETENTION AND ETHICAL MOTIVATION

Retention is earned by better recommendations and real-world outcomes — never by anxiety, public popularity or punitive streaks.

MECHANIC	MVP IMPLEMENTATION	GUARDRAIL
Soul Drop	Up to five curated people or outings weekly, refreshed by local density	No infinite feed, no artificial countdown
Profile depth	Optional layers thicken the Bloom and sharpen explanations	Never withhold safety or basic access; no completion percentage
You First	Answer a light prompt before selected community responses unlock	No sensitive prompts; skip and private mode always available
Outing credits	Light credits for verified attendance and useful feedback	Never turn friendship into pay-to-win
Saved possibilities	Save people or outings for later	No manipulative "they may disappear" messaging
Outing Records	Private recap of attended outings and moments	Consent required for shared photos or tagging
Return Keys	A gentle prompt to reconnect with a promising person	Limit frequency; always muteable

Notification rules

Maximum three notifications per user per week. Nothing with a count in it.

EVENT	CHANNEL	TIMING AND LIMIT
Join request received	Push + in-app	Immediate; multiple requests bundled
Request accepted or declined	Push + in-app	Immediate; neutral wording for declines
Outing reminder	Push	24 hours and 2 hours before; user configurable
Host action needed	Push	24 hours before the request deadline
Rhythm Check	Push + in-app	~24 hours after the scheduled end; one reminder only
Soul Drop	Push, optional	Weekly at a user-selected day and time
Reconnect prompt	In-app; push opt-in	No more than one per week

Never sent: "someone viewed your profile", "you have 3 new matches", streak reminders, or any re-engagement nudge that exists to restart a session rather than to move a plan forward.

11 Trust, safety and consent

REQUIRED INFRASTRUCTURE

LAYER	MVP REQUIREMENT
Identity and eligibility	Age gate, verified email or phone, one-account controls, profile photo standards
Privacy	Broad neighbourhood before acceptance; exact venue revealed only when needed; granular profile visibility; private values excluded from scoring and never leave the server
Interaction boundaries	No open DMs; coordination thread only after an accepted outing or mutual invitation
Host and attendee controls	Block, remove attendee, leave outing, cancel, report and mute
Reliability	Attendance states, cancellations and no-show tracking, held as non-public context
Content moderation	Automated flagging plus human review for profiles, outing pitches and thread reports
Incident response	Severity levels, evidence preservation, temporary restrictions, appeal pathway
Consent	Explicit consent for photos, shared memories and any future public content
Matching fairness V2.0	Race, religion, nationality and language are never inputs to scoring, as features or proxies. A test asserts that shuffling those fields leaves rankings unchanged.

Reporting taxonomy

- Harassment, hate or discriminatory behaviour.
- Sexual or romantic boundary violation in a friendship-only context.
- Impersonation, scam or misleading identity.

- Unsafe outing, coercion or location concern.
- Underage user or age misrepresentation.
- Repeated no-show, spam or disruptive hosting.
- Inappropriate content or privacy violation.

SAFETY SEPARATION

A low compatibility read is not a safety report. Preference learning, reliability signals and misconduct escalation are three separate systems and must never be merged into a single reputation number.

First-meeting guidance

Shown on every *first* confirmed outing with a new person: public place, tell someone, leave whenever you want. Warm and brief — three lines, not a legal notice.

12 Data model

CORE ENTITIES

Typed columns for anything the matching engine reads — fast, indexable and auditable.

Open-ended extras go in JSON. The trait vector is deliberately *not* one large blob, because every recommendation must be explainable after the fact.

ENTITY	KEY FIELDS
profiles	id, handle, display_name, photo, home_area, birth_year, age_pref, profile_version, confidence, tier, status
trait_personality	ten normalised trait columns, answered count, updated_at
trait_communication	behaviour/expectation pairs for cadence, speed and initiation; mediums[], conv_styles[]
trait_social_rhythm	availability[] (28 slots), planning_horizon, social_freq self/expect, duration, energy_peak
trait_intent	intents[], depth (0–4), open_to_hosting
trait_emotional	five Emotional Rhythm columns plus static style columns
trait_lifestyle	budget_band, alcohol, smoking, activity_level, life_stage, food_prefs[], accessibility_needs[], dealbreakers[]
trait_experience	settings[], group_size_pref, orientation[], novelty
trait_geography	home_area, radius_minutes per activity category
user_values	value_key, stance, importance, visibility (private / matching-only / public)
interest_nodes / user_interests	tree with ltree path; affinity of love / regular / learning / curious
match_scores	resonance, logistics, rank, gated, per-dimension contributions, profile versions
match_explanations	click_text, friction_text (non-empty by constraint), generated_by, versions

ENTITY	KEY FIELDS
match_surfaced	viewer, shown, week_of, action — enforces the five-per-week cap
outings	host_id, title, pitch, activity_category, area, starts_at, duration, budget_band, orientation, max_participants, visibility, state
outing_members	outing_id, user_id, role, state (invited / requested / accepted / declined / removed)
outing_records	headline, photo_urls[], attended[]
rhythm_checks	author, about, would_meet_again, energy_read, pace_read, note
blocks / reports / notifications / recommendation_events	as in v1.0

Row-level security posture

TABLE	READ	WRITE
trait_* and user_values	Self only. Another user's raw traits never reach a client.	Self only
match_scores	Nobody. Server-side only.	Service role only
match_explanations	Either party in the pair	Service role only
rhythm_checks	Author only — never the subject	Author only
outing_members	Host and members	Host controls invitations and approvals; guests control only their own row

Data governance

- Separate authentication data, public profile data, sensitive matching data and moderation data.
- Store user-editable summaries separately from raw answers and derived vectors.
- Log model and ruleset versions for every recommendation explanation.
- Allow export, correction and deletion of personal data.
- Use the minimum sensitive data required; define retention limits for reports and threads.
- Never use private reflections as public reputation scores.

13 Technical architecture

REVISED IN V2.0

PLATFORM DECISION CHANGED

v1.0 specified React Native with Expo. v2.0 builds an **installable Next.js PWA first**, with all business logic in a framework-free shared core package, and a native Expo app later that reuses that core unchanged. This reaches the 30-person concierge test faster, avoids App Store review in the learning phase, and keeps native cheap.

LAYER	RECOMMENDATION	WHY
Client	Next.js 15 App Router, TypeScript strict, Tailwind, installable PWA	One codebase, instant iteration, no store gate during the test
Shared core	packages/core — matching, domain types, explanation building. Zero React, Next or database imports.	This is what makes the native app cheap later
Backend	Supabase: Postgres, Auth, Storage, Realtime, Edge Functions	Relational model, row-level security, low ops
Matching	Pure TypeScript, unit-tested, no I/O	Inspectable and tunable without touching the app
AI layer	Frontier-tier model for match explanations and trust-and-safety review; a cheaper mid-tier model for bulk text such as interest normalisation. Keys server-side only.	Quality where it is read by a human; cost control everywhere else
Admin	Retool or a lightweight internal dashboard	Moderation and operations without a full back office
Analytics	PostHog or Amplitude	Funnels, retention, experiments
Notifications	Web push for the PWA; Expo Notifications when native ships	Adequate for a closed test
Maps / places	A static Singapore planning-area travel-time matrix in v0.1	No routing API call per match; deterministic and free
Moderation	Rules plus vendor API plus human review	Layered defence rather than model-only decisions

AI service boundaries

- **Allowed:** synthesise user-approved Friendship DNA summaries, write explanations from structured phrases, suggest outing wording, classify content for moderation review.
- **Not allowed:** infer protected traits, diagnose mental health, make safety decisions without policy logic, fabricate certainty, or reveal another user's private answers.
- **Never sent to a model:** raw trait vectors, compatibility scores, or any private-flagged value. Only pre-written human phrases.
- Every generation uses a structured schema, length limits, safety filters and deterministic fallback copy. A match is never shown without an explanation.
- Explanations are cached and regenerated only when a profile or scoring version materially changes.

Build order

MILESTONE	SCOPE	DONE WHEN
M0	Monorepo, Next.js, Supabase, design tokens, CI	A blank page renders in the brand palette and tests run green

MILESTONE	SCOPE	DONE WHEN
M1	Matching engine, headless, test-first	Twelve specified test cases pass; a CLI prints a ranked table for two profiles
M2	Schema, RLS, cap trigger, interest tree, 40 synthetic profiles	Ranking over the seeded cohort is plausible and auditable
M3	Design-system primitives — Bloom first	Every primitive renders at 390px and 1024px, with reduced motion and keyboard focus
M4	Auth and the core onboarding pass	A real person reaches a matching-eligible profile in under five minutes
M5	Soul Drop, Resonance Reads, person detail	Reads are judged accurate by a human reviewer, friction included
M6	Pitch Outings with host control and cohesion advisories	Two accounts go pitch → confirmed; a seventh invite is impossible at every layer
M7	Outing Records, Rhythm Checks, recalibration, safety	The loop closes and matches visibly shift after a real outing
M8	PWA polish, empty states, notification limits, accessibility, analytics	Success metrics instrumented; every screen passes the visual checklist

14 Measuring real connection

SUCCESS METRICS

NORTH-STAR METRIC — MEANINGFUL FRIENDSHIP STARTS

A pair of users who attend at least one shared outing and then demonstrate reciprocal continuation within 30 days — another outing, a mutual invitation, or both indicating they want to meet again.

LAYER	METRIC	INITIAL DIRECTIONAL TARGET
Activation	Core Friendship DNA completed	≥ 65% of signed-up users
Activation	User views at least three match explanations	≥ 50% of activated users
Explanation quality V2.0	Users rating the friction section as accurate	Qualitative in closed beta; ≥ 60% agreement
Marketplace	Outing detail → join request	≥ 12%
Host conversion	Join request → accepted	Track by capacity and host segment
Host conversion V2.0	Pitches reaching a confirmed guest list	≥ 60%
Offline conversion	Accepted → attended	≥ 65% (≥ 75% in the 30-person test)
Outcome	Attendees selecting "would meet again"	≥ 55%; median Rhythm Check ≥ 4 / 5

LAYER	METRIC	INITIAL DIRECTIONAL TARGET
Continuation V 2.0	Attendees meeting the same person again within six weeks	≥ 40%
Retention	Week-4 retained among attendees	≥ 35%
Quality	Report rate per attended outing	Monitor by severity; prioritise a low serious-incident rate
Supply	Active hosts creating a second outing within 30 days	≥ 25%
North star	MFS per 100 activated users	Baseline in closed beta, then improve cohort over cohort

Analytics event taxonomy

- onboarding_started · onboarding_step_completed · dna_completed · dna_summary_edited · confidence_threshold_reached
- soul_drop_viewed · match_opened · explanation_expanded · friction_expanded · person_saved · recommendation_dismissed
- outing_created · outing_published · cohesion_warning_shown · cohesion_warning_overridden · join_request_submitted · request_accepted
- thread_opened · reminder_opened · attendance_confirmed · outing_cancelled · no_show_recorded
- rhythm_check_submitted · would_meet_again · recalibration_surfaced · repeat_outing_created · block_created · report_submitted

15 State rules and edge cases

PRODUCT COMPLETENESS

SCENARIO	REQUIRED BEHAVIOUR
Outing fills while a request is pending	Keep accepted members; close remaining requests with neutral copy, or offer a waitlist. Pending invitations already hold seats, so this should be rare.
Host cancels	Notify all members immediately, close the thread after a grace period, record the cancellation separately from attendee reliability.
Attendee withdraws	Release capacity; optionally surface the waitlist; apply reliability only according to timing policy.
Host removes an accepted attendee	Require a reason category for internal audit; notify the attendee neutrally without exposing the reason; preserve the report path.
A member blocks another in the same outing	Hide direct interaction, alert safety operations where necessary, offer a safe exit or removal workflow.
Low local density	Show high-quality future outings, host prompts and a wider radius rather than irrelevant people. Never fill the Soul Drop to five with poor matches.
AI summary or explanation fails	Use the deterministic template from stored phrases. Never block onboarding, and never show a match without an explanation.

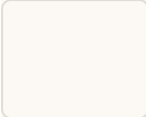
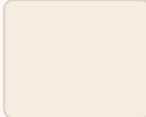
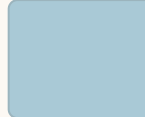
SCENARIO	REQUIRED BEHAVIOUR
Recommendation has weak evidence	Say "worth exploring", show limited reasons, and hedge the read as early rather than inventing depth.
User changes home area or life season	Bump profile version, invalidate cached scores and explanations, recompute practical fit, preserve history.
Private venue or home setting	Disallowed or heavily restricted in MVP; public venues by default.
Outing crosses midnight or timezone	Store UTC plus local timezone; display explicit local date and time.
Account deletion with hosted future outings	Require transfer or cancellation before deletion; anonymise past analytical records where lawful.
Both users in a pair fall below confidence V2.0	Suppress the pair entirely rather than degrade the read. Thin data is a reason to show nothing.

16 Experience and visual direction

BRAND TRANSLATED INTO PRODUCT

Warm, tactile and editorial: a light ground, illustrated depth, and type doing the heavy lifting. The product should feel soulful and modern while staying highly legible and operationally clear.

Palette

							
Paper #FCF8F3	Sand #F5EDE1	Espresso #2B211B	Terracotta #D9663F	Sage #3E6B5C	Amber #EFA93C	Clay #B0836A	Sky #A9C9D6

Clay is the friction colour. Difference between two people is information, not an error, so nothing in this product applies a red-and-green judgement palette to a human being. No pure white and no pure black anywhere; shadows are warm, never grey.

ATTRIBUTE	DIRECTION
Typography	Fraunces for display and headings; Inter for all functional UI. Every screen carries at least one display-size element and one label-size element — interfaces look like slide decks when everything sits at 16–20px.
Layout	An illustrated ground on every primary screen. Cards overlap and break the column. Asymmetric splits, never three equal cards. Body text left-aligned, never centred paragraphs.
Components	Generous radii, soft warm elevation, restrained hairline borders, clear status chips.
Illustration	Hand-drawn line quality with visible texture, warm topographic contours as a recurring motif, subtle paper grain. Never flat corporate figures with oversized limbs.
Photography	Natural, candid, friendship-first; avoid romantic couple-coded imagery and stock groups laughing.

ATTRIBUTE	DIRECTION
Motion	Slow staggered reveals, parallax grounds, warm confirmation blooms. No confetti. Reduced-motion collapses everything to a short fade.
Accessibility	WCAG-conscious contrast verified in CI, dynamic type, alt text, non-colour status cues, 44px targets, full keyboard navigation.
Copy	Warm, specific and non-judgmental. "This may fit because..." over absolute claims.

Signature components

COMPONENT	SPECIFICATION
Friendship DNA Bloom	An organic radial form, eight petals, one per dimension. Petal <i>length</i> encodes expression; petal <i>width</i> encodes confidence, so an incomplete profile is visibly thin. Tapping a petal reveals a sentence, never a number. Two blooms overlaid translucently are the compatibility visualisation. Not a bar chart, not a radar chart, not a percentage.
Resonance Read	Two parts, always in order, always both visible. The friction section is never collapsed, never behind a tap, never smaller than the positive section.
Rhythm Strip	Seven columns by four rows of the week, filled as soft watercolour washes. On a match screen, two strips overlay and the shared slots glow.
Pitch Card	Reads like a handwritten invitation, not an event listing. Seats shown as filled and empty illustrated chairs, never "4/6".
Tribe Map	An illustrated terrain holding your circle. Static backdrop in v0.1, data-driven nodes from the start, interactive later.

BANNED PATTERNS

Centred hero → three equal cards → centred CTA. Full-width alternating colour bands. Default grey component-library neutrals. Glassmorphism and mesh gradients. Percentage match scores or star ratings on people. Progress bars for the DNA. Emoji as interface iconography. Grey empty states. Stock photography of diverse people laughing.

The v1.0 moodboard has been retired from this document. Its reference images contained generated placeholder text and rendered UI that cannot be built from; the palette, component and layout specifications above replace it as the production direction.

17 Launch and rollout

DENSITY BEFORE SCALE

PHASE	COHORT	OBJECTIVE	EXIT CRITERIA
Alpha	30 invited testers and hosts	Validate onboarding, the matching model and the outing state machine	Core flows complete without manual fixes; reads judged accurate
Closed beta 1	150–300 users in 2–3 Singapore clusters	Test recommendation relevance and outing conversion	Consistent requests, attendance and usable feedback

PHASE	COHORT	OBJECTIVE	EXIT CRITERIA
Closed beta 2	500–1,000 users with community partners	Test density, moderation and repeat hosting	Repeat outing supply and stable safety operations
Public city launch	Curated Singapore rollout	Prove a repeatable local growth loop	MFS and retention improve across cohorts

Supply strategy

- Recruit founding hosts who already convene thoughtful groups: creatives, newcomers, founders, wellness and interest-led micro-communities.
- Seed high-quality Pitch Outings before opening each neighbourhood or cluster.
- Use partnerships to add trusted density, not top-of-funnel volume.
- Give hosts templates, suggested venues and clear safety guidance.
- Measure host repeat rate and attendee continuation, not registrations.

Operational readiness checklist

- Community guidelines, privacy policy, terms and age requirements reviewed for Singapore launch.
- Moderation queue with named ownership and severity-based response times.
- Escalation plan for safety incidents and law-enforcement requests.
- Host playbook, cancellation policy, no-show policy and support macros.
- Analytics dashboards for funnel, density, reports, cancellations and MFS.
- Deterministic fallback copy for every AI-generated surface.

18 Open decisions and risks

FOUNDER REVIEW

DECISION	RECOMMENDED MVP STANCE	WHY IT MATTERS
Group size cap RESOLVED	Six including the host , enforced in the database	Six is where conversation splits into sub-groups; it also keeps cohesion computable and hosting manageable
1:1 outings vs groups	Support both; default discovery toward 3–5 person public outings during safety testing	Different users need different pressure levels; public groups reduce risk
Compatibility score display RESOLVED	Never show a number. Language and the Bloom only	Avoids false scientific authority and social ranking of people
Demographic preferences	Limit to user-led safety and comfort cases; review policy carefully	Can support comfort but also enable exclusion
Exact location visibility	Reveal after acceptance; public venue by default	Balances decision clarity and privacy
Direct people invitations	Only contextual invitations to a specific outing	Preserves agency without open unsolicited messaging

DECISION	RECOMMENDED MVP STANCE	WHY IT MATTERS
Messaging depth REVISED	A thin coordination thread with hand-off to the group's own chat	Soul Tribe is a layer above chat; competing with WhatsApp would dilute the artifact thesis
Paid features	Delay subscriptions; test paid hosted experiences later	Connection quality must be proven first
Reliability display	Contextual badges, never public scores	Useful trust signal without permanent social punishment
Weight tuning OPEN	Freeze the weights for v0.1; tune only against outcome data after 100+ outings	Tuning on intuition mid-test makes the results uninterpretable

Top risks

RISK	MITIGATION
Cold start and low density	Cluster launch, founding hosts, pre-seeded outings, limited radii and waitlists
Matching feels generic	Specific structured dimensions, honest explanations, editable profiles, rapid feedback tuning
Onboarding length deters signup V2.0	Only 12 questions are required; the rest are earned with visible payoff. Monitor drop-off per screen and cut questions that do not move match quality.
Outings do not convert to attendance	Clear logistics, host approval deadlines, reminders and reliability design
The friction section feels harsh V2.0	Neutral phrasing rules, banned-word list, no advice, clay rather than red. Test the copy in alpha before scaling.
Friendship app becomes dating-adjacent	Explicit norms, a reporting category, product language and no romantic mechanics
AI overclaims or stereotypes	Structured prompts, user correction, policy filters, audits, no protected-trait inference, demographic-invariance test
Safety incident damages trust	Public-venue defaults, limited messaging, reporting, moderation and incident response
Product becomes emotionally extractive	No punitive streaks, no popularity metrics, capped notifications, private feedback

19 Shipping checklist

MVP DEFINITION OF DONE

- A new user completes a consent-aware Friendship DNA core pass in under five minutes and can edit the generated summary.
- Matching activates only above the confidence threshold; thin profiles are never surfaced.
- The home experience presents a limited, relevant Soul Drop of people and outings.
- Every recommendation carries specific grounded reasons *and* a friction note, with no invented private information.

- No compatibility number is visible anywhere in the product or reachable through the API.
- A host can create, publish, edit, cancel and manage a Pitch Outing to a maximum of six participants, enforced in the database.
- Cohesion advisories appear as the guest list changes and never block the host.
- A user can request to join, track status, withdraw and receive neutral outcomes.
- Accepted members access logistics and the coordination thread; strangers cannot message one another.
- Every completed outing produces an Outing Record, and a Rhythm Check that is never visible to its subject.
- Recalibration is visible to the user in plain language.
- Users can block and report from all relevant surfaces; moderation has an operational queue.
- Analytics capture the full activation → request → acceptance → attendance → continuation funnel.
- The app meets baseline accessibility, privacy, security and performance requirements, and every screen passes the visual checklist.
- Closed-beta operations can support incidents, host questions and content review.

THE MVP TEST

Can Soul Tribe repeatedly turn "I want better friends" into a safe, concrete real-world interaction that both people genuinely want to continue?

Product sentence for the team

Build the smallest trustworthy system that understands a person deeply enough to recommend the right people, gives them enough agency to create a fitting real-world plan, and learns honestly — including about friction — whether that connection was worth continuing.